



An Introduction to Graphviz

Graphviz is an open source software for creating graphs. In this article, we'll introduce Graphviz and see how it is different from other graph-drawing software. Then we'll use the reflection feature in Java and Graphviz to show how easy it is to 'automatically' create inheritance hierarchy diagrams for Java library classes.

We often need to generate figures and diagrams. A graph is one of the most natural and widely-used diagrams. We typically don't recognise that we are using graphs in many diagrams; for example: a flow chart of

a simple program, a family tree, a directory structure in a file-system, a chart of links of your friends on social networking sites, bus routes for your city, or the organisation chart of your company. We also don't usually recognise the use and importance of